



Guide for Al Manar Stories





Al-Manar Stories

The Al-Manar story series was a project adopted by the Ministry of Education, Oman to instill in the hearts of children a love of reading and to further develop their reading skills. Each week, a child can choose a story to read from this book box in their free reading classes. The child with the help of their teacher selects a story according to his/her level, needs and interests.

Themes in the Al-Manar Story Series

The themes covered in the Al-Manar story series are aimed at instilling the human values of citizenship, coexistence with others, respect for others including people with special needs, accepting reality, expressing satisfaction and gratitude, whilst at the same time encouraging children to be reflective, creative, and generous. These values are implicit and symbolic in most of the stories, which means that the teacher, should delve into the content, to get a sense of the feelings, values, and behaviours that each story can convey to the child.

The Al-Manar story series are suitable for every child over the world. Furthermore, they have been converted into audio and visual stories, and are also available in sign language.

The values in the stories

As mentioned previously, each story includes different values that requires the reader, whether the student or teacher, to pay attention to the implicit values that each story tackles. Some of the values listed below, which can be explained in more detail, so that children can understand the value of each story at a much deeper level.

When can the stories be applied in the classroom?

- The goal for creating the Al Manar stories series was to spread the culture of reading for enjoyment in school and at home as a book is a friend that can be used anywhere at any time throughout one's lifetime.
- The English Senior Teacher will be responsible for the story series in each school.
- It can be applied in the free reading lessons.
- It can be used in substitution lessons, so that children can get additional practice in reading.
- Children can borrow a story for a day, but their names need to be recorded in a special book that is kept purely for this purpose.
- Teachers can use the stories to enrich different linguistic skills such as summarizing, writing, and any other activities that the teacher deems suitable.
- The stories are recorded in audio and video format and will be distributed to schools so that they can be used to encourage students to listen and read the stories at the same time.
- Teachers can innovate as to how best to use the series in the English language classes.

1

The Adventures of Bio and Bia

This story includes a set of values and behaviours that a child can learn. The most important of which are:

- The value of work (the lazy bees have no place in the hive)
- Patience and endurance are needed to reach a goal (no pain, no gain).
- Love of home (all attempts by Bio and Bia to obtain comfort and happiness elsewhere are not successful, so the hive representing their home becomes very important for them).

2

The Wise Ant

This story promotes values and behaviours which are:

- The importance of discussing problems and working as a team.
- Never to underestimate anyone or anything no matter how small or how weak they appear to be.
- Power comes with wisdom, and work. It is not the result of how strong one is.
- The importance of cooperation and taking responsibility for each other even during hard times.

3

The Needle and the Thread

This story addresses values and behaviours including:

- The importance of friendship.
- Appreciating each other's qualities and accepting the differences that exist between us.
- The concept of integration and cooperation.
- The importance of volunteering and helping others.



4

The Teller of Tales

This story is a kind of fantasy that children will appreciate. It can be used to talk about the importance of future dreams, and how a human being can fulfil his or her dream even if he or she is poor. It promotes within the child:

- The importance of having dreams and pursuing them.
- Using one's imagination and instilling in children a love of adventure.
- The importance of developing and practising talents if one wishes to succeed.
- Self-reliance and using one's initiative to achieve success.
- Appreciation of all that a mother/guardian does to help her children succeed in life.

5

A Rainbow without Colours

From this story, the child learns:

- The value of helping others and understanding their problems.
- The value of giving.
- The value of coexistence.
- How a mother's love knows no bounds and accepts her children as they are.

6

Ceres and Vista

- This story can be used to introduce space and science fiction to a child.
- The story includes information about the planets.
- The story calls for emotions to be expressed and not held back.
- The story reinforces the importance of making friendships with others who have similar interests and/or goals.

7

The Little Grain of Wheat

The story stresses the importance of:

- Independence and not relying completely on our parents and other role models.
- Having patience and endurance to cope with the challenges that one may encounter in life.
- Aiding others when one is able to help.

8

The Beautiful Red Bird

This story reinforces:

- The value of belonging to a place/country.
- Using one's initiative to find solutions to any challenges faced.
- The values of loyalty, work, and optimism.

9

Pico

- The story promotes a child's love for reading and books.
- It encourages the child to aspire to distinction and excellence.
- It teaches the child the value of seeking knowledge through research.

10

Jabool and the Crusher

From this story the child learns:

- The conflict between right and wrong and the triumph of good over evil.
- The importance of facing the consequences of one's actions.
- The values of forgiveness, and tolerance.
- Respect for the natural environment.
- The value of teamwork in finding solutions to any challenges faced.

11

Aryosha's Adventures

The child learns the following from this story:

- The value of patience when facing difficulties.
- The value of helping others.
- The importance of self-reliance if one is to reach one's goal.

12

Ornasa

The story is a kind of science fiction through which the child learns:

- The importance of developing and practising hobbies.
- The value in accepting others as they are.
- The value of living in peace.
- The importance of helping others when they are in need.
- What it means to belong to a family.

13

The Little Giant

- It teaches the child not to make hasty judgments about others.
- It enhances the value of being a team member.
- It encourages the child to recognize and appreciate others' talents for the benefit of all.

14

Miss Excavator

The child learns from this story:

- The concept of being different.
- The importance of learning to appreciate oneself and one's talents.
- The value of work.
- The value of volunteering and helping others.
- The concept of developing one's talents for the benefit of others.

15

The Greedy Boy

This story discusses the subject of slenderness and obesity, through which the child learns:

- How to respect and accept each other as they are.
- The importance of being kind to each other and not to call each other disrespectful names.
- Self-acceptance and trying to improve oneself.
- The value of courage and doing the right thing.

16

The Jingle Ball

The story talks about people with disabilities, and it instills in the child:

- The value of competing with a good spirit.
- Everyone has a value and a role in life.
- The concept that we are all different and that everyone has talents that can be used to help others succeed in life.

17

The Little Mantis

This story addresses the importance of work, and it reinforces important values and concepts such as:

- Everyone is unique with our own special characteristics.
- The importance of self-acceptance.
- We should not compare ourselves to others.
- Enhancing the feeling of satisfaction and self-confidence.

18

Tamara's Journey

This story tells the story about the journey of one date, that was lived in the spirit of adventure and discovery. In this story the child learns:

- The value of helping others.
- The value of work.
- The importance of farming and agriculture in our lives.
- The love of environment and nature.

19

The Golden Crown

This story reinforces the motive for exploration and adventure in the child, and at the same time it teaches the child:

- The value of a human being lies in his/her morals and behaviour, not in his/her appearance.
- The concept of belonging and friendship.
- The value of humility, and it warns the child of the consequences of being vain and arrogant.
- The importance of not taking things that belong to others.
- The importance of having respect for other people and things.
- The importance of being kind and polite to everyone.

20

Friends Under the Sea

From this story, the child learns:

- The importance of being confident.
- The importance of friendship.
- Cooperation and unity.
- The value of giving help to others when they are in need.

21

The Scary Storm

In this story, a group of young animals are exposed to a frightening hurricane, and they become separated as a result. The purpose of this story is to promote some values such as

- Not to abandon friends during hard times.
- Accepting difficult circumstances and seeing the bright side of life.
- The importance of love and belonging to a place/home.
- It is good to be adventurous sometimes and have the courage to go somewhere new.



22

The Golden Horseshoe

This story is a legendary fantasy, and it promotes:

- The value of work.
- The value of helping others.
- A love of horses.
- The importance of being kind to animals.
- The concept that hard work together with ambition is the way to make dreams come true.

23

The Princess and the Strange Island

This story is a kind of fantasy that children will appreciate, and through it a child learns:

- The value of learning and distinction.
- The importance of cooperation and unity.
- That we should help our parents.
- The value of friendship.
- The importance of bringing joy to others through the puppet play that the father presents to the children in the theatre.
- That we should be kind to strangers even though they look and behave differently to us.

24

The Magic Watch

This story encourages children to talk about inventions and innovations. Through its events, certain values and behaviours are reinforced in the child, including:

- Promoting the concept of self-control.
- Encouraging the values of honesty and truthfulness.
- Promoting the value of good faith and appreciating life's blessings, no matter how small.
- The value of humour and the importance of being able to laugh at oneself.
- The importance of observation and noticing things.
- It teaches the child that it is good to use the internet to find out how things work.

25

The Halwa Maker

This is a folk story that teaches the child:

- The importance of working hard in one's career.
- Wishing only good for others.
- The importance of helping the poor and the needy.
- Not to be envious of others.
- To avoid people who talk badly about others or spread gossip about them.
- To choose one's friends wisely.

26

The Son of the Moon

In this story, the child recognizes some of the rare health conditions that some children suffer from, through which he/she learns a range of values, the most important of which are:

- The value of wishing only good for others.
- The importance of accepting ourselves as we are.
- The value of living in harmony with each other.
- Having an optimistic attitude in life.
- How much a mother loves her child and always does her best to protect them.

27

The Twins

In this story, the child recognizes this rare condition of conjoined twins, and it promotes:

- The principle of sharing.
- The value of brotherhood/sisterhood.
- Accepting life and not giving into despair.
- The idea that no matter how challenging the situation, there can be a positive outcome.

28

The Rial's Adventure

This story addresses some financial related values and behaviours like saving, spending and investment. Through it the child learns:

- To be generous and help others.
- To avoid anything that is harmful or is bad for one's health.
- That it is not good to cheat people.
- The importance of reading, writing, and visiting the library.
- The positive feeling of belonging to a family and having friends.

29

The Queen of Pots

From this story the child learns:

- The value of a human being is measured by his/her deeds not their appearance.
- Everything or everyone has a specific and important role in life.
- That it is dangerous to go too close to a fire or a lighted candle!
- Self-esteem is important.
- The value of honest competition.
- Respect for people with special needs.
- That for every cloud there is a silver lining.
- What starts off badly can end up being surprisingly successful- There is always hope!

30

Great Ideas

Through this story, some values are reinforced such as:

- Promoting creative thinking and innovation.
- Encouraging children to recycle things to save our environment.
- Demonstrating that by practicing and developing our talents we can achieve great success.
- The importance of depending on oneself in life.

31

The Talking Wall

This story talks about the importance of science, knowledge, and wisdom. It enhances a set of important values in the child which are:

- The value of beauty and taking care of the environment.
- The value of using our minds to solve problems and challenges in life.
- The value of science, knowledge, and wisdom.
- The importance of being able to communicate with others in their own language.

32

Waleed and the Olive Tree

This story highlights the issue of bullying, and it reinforces the following values:

- The importance of self-defence.
- Preservation of rights and properties.
- Standing up for what is right in life.
- A love of horses.
- That it is not good to be nasty to others.

33

Bouncy

This story talks about making comparisons between children, which can result in the child becoming anxious, jealous, and hyper-sensitive. Through this story, the child learns a range of important behaviours, including:

- The distinction between negative comparisons and positive competition.
- A child's search for what distinguishes him/her from others.
- Not to rush in judging others.
- That we each have a role to play in life.
- The importance of developing our unique talents.



34

The Magic Herb

This story ascertains that love is the cure. It reinforces the following values in the child:

- The importance of loving our parents and looking after them when they are ill.
- The strong bond that exists between a mother and her daughter.
- By helping others, we will get help when we need it most.
- The importance of searching for the truth.

35

The Strange Trees

This story addresses the issue of rumors circulating in societies, and instills a set of values in the child, the most important of which are:

- The value of agriculture and preserving the environment.
- Not to listen to rumours and not to repeat them to other people.
- Respect for elders because they are wise and know what they are talking about.
- Hard work brings its own rewards.
- That the grass on the other side is not always greener or better.

36

The Queen of Jasmine

This story talks about the importance of science and knowledge in building the personality of a human being, and the importance of seeking knowledge no matter how difficult the circumstances. It promotes certain values in the child, including:

- Enhancing the value of work.
- Enhancing the value of education and science.
- The importance of depending on oneself in life.
- Instilling a sense of love for fellow human beings.
- The importance of spreading joy in society.
- That where there is a will, there is always a way to achieve our dreams.

37

Anees's Nightmares

This story talks about how children can become stressed when parents unintentionally seem to favor one child over another. Through this story the child learns:

- The necessity of expressing their feelings.
- To trust their parents and to realize that parents love each one of their children.
- Addressing certain feelings such as jealousy and fear.
- Promoting a sense of love and belonging to the family.

38

The Wise Old Man's Shadow

This is a story from Arab folklore that shows the importance of helping others, through which the child learns:

- The value of being kind and generous to others.
- The importance of taking responsibility for one's actions.
- The value of truthfulness and honesty.

39

The Girl Made of Glass

This story talks about children who suffer from a condition that causes bones to become weak and lose their strength, making them break more easily than normal bones. This story symbolizes all the pathological conditions that these children suffer from, and through this story children learn:

- The importance of considering the special needs of some children.
- Not to judge others without knowing their circumstances.
- The value of brotherhood/sisterhood, and the brother's deep love for his sister and how much he cares for her.

40

The End of Foxy

The purpose of this story is to warn children about certain things, including:

- The need to be cautious when dealing with strangers.
- That it is very bad to make fools out of people and/or play nasty jokes on them.
- That our actions have consequences, so if we do something bad it will eventually cause us pain.
- To trust one's elders and tell them about all the upsetting situations one is subjected to, no matter how small the issue.

Telling Stories: Why and How?

- Stories are a powerful tool in language learning and the development of young children. They are an excellent way to introduce language and contribute to the child's whole development.
- They can also provide the starting point for a wide range of activities. Stories, and activities based on them, are a very natural way of linking English with other subjects in the Basic Education curriculum, and of making learning more attractive and interesting.
- Stories expose children to a large amount of comprehensible input. They provide the language to engage children in purposeful communication, and present situations that are common in stories and important to the world of children.
- Stories present language in a context which is meaningful to children. The language that appears in the stories plays a specific role within the content. This helps children to understand and memorize the language more easily.
- Rhyme, Rhythm and Repetition multiply exposure to language, and make it memorable. Cumulative stories allow phrases to be rehearsed again and again. Children's stories are a rich source of natural repetition. They contain patterns that are repeated throughout the narration. This natural repetition encourages children to participate actively either by joining in, or by creating new sentences.
- Stories help develop children's creativity and liking for stories. Children who listen to, or read, stories become far more creative and imaginative than those who are deprived of this opportunity.
- Stories often provide models of good behaviour to imitate, or reinforce good patterns of behaviour such as following parents' advice, being kind to animals, etc.
- Stories are fun! Never under-estimate the motivation to learning provided by enjoyment. Picture books from countries are usually very well-written and illustrated, and they offer a chance to laugh, to be excited (and to be scared!) together.
- The social aspects of listening together; the improvements in concentration and confidence; and the benefits of interaction (actions, refrains, prediction, discussion), are valuable extra gains.
- Stories (especially told from memory) fuel the power of imagination.
- Stories improve concentration span and give children confidence in participating.
- Stories from picture books stimulate an appreciation of art, and 'ways of seeing'. Good illustrations (for example, in picture books) will support the story, help the learner work out what the accompanying language means, and add detail to its meaning.
- Stories bring objects, people, and places to life. They expand experience - other people, other places, other ways of behaving. At the same time, traditional stories often have parallels with tales in students' own countries, and they can explore the similarities and differences.
- Students 'reading' of detail in the pictures will improve visual literacy and stimulate language use.
- Traditional stories, introduce colloquial language and idiom.
- Stories provide therapy - facing issues safely 'second hand', sharing with others.
- Stories can be either read aloud by the teacher, read by groups of students together, read by two 'reading buddies', or read individually by students.
- Follow-on activities can include discussion after the story (or before, to explain difficult words or ideas - or even during the reading); role play as students can act out the story; creative writing; artwork; recording or videoing the story; and students making their own books.



Strategies to support and extend student learning

Effective reading programs use a balance of modelled, guided, and independent strategies to support and extend student learning.

Modelled and Shared Reading (to the student-learner)

- In modelled reading situations teachers demonstrate reading strategies by sharing the reading process with students. In modelled and shared reading situations:
- Teachers - read to, show, demonstrate, explain, instruct, and interpret student responses.
- Students - watch, engage, listen, follow, share, question and participate.

The main purposes of shared reading in schools are for children:

- to learn through modeling and demonstration how an expert reader gets meaning from a text.
- to experience the conventions of reading a book in English (such as the direction of turning pages and the directionality of text).
- to learn about story structure.
- to learn how illustrations support meaning.
- to use knowledge of meaning to predict unknown words.
- to link memory of repetitive chunks to the written word.
- to see the relationship between written words and their sounds and meaning.
- to read and become familiar with high frequency grammatical words in context.
- to enjoy a collaborative reading experience.
- to develop a positive attitude to reading.
- to develop confidence in themselves as readers.

Practising and Telling Stories to the whole class

- Read through the story first. Look for high points in the story, or for where pauses could be used. Look for the 'three Rs': rhythm, rhyme and repetition. Choruses, refrains, and animal noises are great for children to join in. Are there opportunities for children to predict? Are there difficult words, to explain in advance?
- Read, and listen to, the story several times until you have learnt it by heart. It may be useful to record yourself telling the story to make sure you get the correct intonation, and your voice conveys the right feelings.
- When you have memorized the story, rehearse it - in front of a mirror if possible - using all the realia, gestures, and expressions, as if you were in front of the class. Practice a read-through first. You could read to your own child, or a friend, to gain confidence.
- Organize any realia and visuals beforehand so that you have what is necessary to reinforce the meaning and make the story come alive.
- Think of a way to introduce the story. "Do you have a pet? Well, here's a story about a boy, who had a horse..." Is there opportunity for using a 'prop' of some kind, or a puppet?
- Think about using different voices; this is particularly useful in dialogue, to separate different characters speaking, and you could deepen your voice for an elephant or giant and raise it for a queen or a fairy.
- Have a choice of stories; if one is not working, just try another. If it works well, be ready to tell it again!
- Let any follow-up flow naturally from the story. Announce it later - just enjoy the story together first!

Before you start telling the story in class

- Before listening to, or reading the story, allow the children to focus on the pictures.
- Ask the children questions about the pictures so that they are more familiar with the subject matter before they hear the story.
- Elicit the vocabulary they already know and teach any key vocabulary essential to general understanding.

While telling the story in class

- Arrange the children so that everyone is sitting comfortably and that they are in a position where they can see both text and pictures in the book easily.
- Use your finger or a pointer to demonstrate directionality whether it is English.
- As you read, point to the words clearly, using your finger or a pointer.
- Speak with a clear voice, and tell the story at the right pace, not too slowly and not too fast. Do not rush the reading. Many people read too fast; some children may need a slower speed than others – especially if they are following the text itself. Speak clearly and make eye contact.
- Try to use a sense of drama, echoing the tone of the words as you say them; you should sound frightened, for example, when you are saying: “We might wake the giant!”
- As you read, pause in appropriate places to talk about the pictures, make predictions and check understanding.
- Use gesture, expression, mime, realia, and change of voice to help children understand the story better.
- As you read, demonstrate reading strategies such as sounding out unknown or difficult words or guessing meanings from pictures or context.
- Encourage children to participate in the story by asking them questions, getting them to predict what happens next, and encourage them to join in when there is a repeated pattern.

- Some stories will contain words and sometimes tenses which the children will not have learned. However, understanding key words and the central events is all that is required of the children.

After telling the story in class

- After reading, close the book and talk to children about the story. Ask them if they liked it? what did they like about it? Can they remember the key characters and events?
- If there is time and if the children are interested, read the story again.

Guided Reading (with the student-learner)

- In guided reading situations teachers work with one student or a small group of students who demonstrate similar reading behaviours and can read similar levels of texts. In guided reading situations:
- Teachers – support, prompt, guide, question, scaffold, observe, instruct, make inferences about further reading, assess and record.
- Students – try, explore, problem-solve, experiment, take risks, approximate, predict, self-correct and practice.

The main purpose of guided reading in schools is:

- To give students the chance to apply the strategies they already know to a new text.



The steps for a guided reading lesson are

- **Before reading:** Set the purpose for reading, introduce vocabulary, make predictions, talk about the strategies good readers use.
- **During reading:** Guide students as they read, provide wait time, give prompts or clues as needed by individual students, such as «Try that again. Does that make sense? Look at how the word begins.»
- **After reading:** Strengthen comprehension skills and provide praise for strategies used by students during the reading.
- **Flexible groupings** are based on student abilities and needs. There are various ways to determine a child's ability level, such as running records, print tests, and teacher observations. Since children progress at different levels, the teacher will need to have a plan for ongoing observation and assessment to track student growth, select appropriate texts, and to regroup students as their needs change. Again, teacher observations and running records can provide valuable information.
- **Choosing Books:** Teachers should choose books that are easy enough for independent reading, meet the instructional goals for the group, and are interesting and motivating to students. As students become more skilled at using a range of reading strategies, the ability level of the texts used in guided reading lessons can be increased. Previously read texts should always be available so that students can reread them independently, with a partner, or at home as they become fluent, confident, and self-motivated readers.



Independent Reading (by the student-learner)

- In independent reading situations teachers construct conditions for students to read, explore and respond to text independently. In independent reading situations:
- Teachers - construct, encourage, respond, question, observe and record.
- Students - initiate, select, use, control, practice, consider, discuss, evaluate, justify, and record.

The main purposes of independent reading in schools are

- To lead to an increased volume of reading as student engagement increases when students can select their own reading material. The more one reads, the better one reads. The more one reads, the more knowledge of words and language one acquires.
- The most critical skill for academic success—and success later in life—is the ability to read well. By creating space for independent reading, you can help students assume more ownership in their learning and discover a passion for reading.

The steps for an independent reading lesson are

- Build independent reading time into each student's day.
- Offer a selection of books at each student's reading level, from different genres and help them find books they might enjoy.
- Let each student make a reading list of five books they want to read and encourage students to set their own personal reading goals.
- Find creative ways for students to share books with one another, including things like book clubs, video projects, or discussion time.
- Use assignments to further engage students.



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